

Project 2: Mapping an Experience

Anya Krishnamony, Abby Miu, Maya Hong, Viraj Aggarwal

ARTF 1250: Designing Interactive Experiences

November 3, 2025

Brainstorming, Research & Observations

Observing Curry

- Focused on 3 different areas: food court, upper floor, and outside (Snell Library Quad)

Location 1: Food Court

- Actions: Mostly working on assignments or just chatting and eating
- Conversations/Relationships: People sitting with friends, suitemates, teammates for group projects, or by themselves
- Moods: Excited, calm, happy, busy, studious, lonely

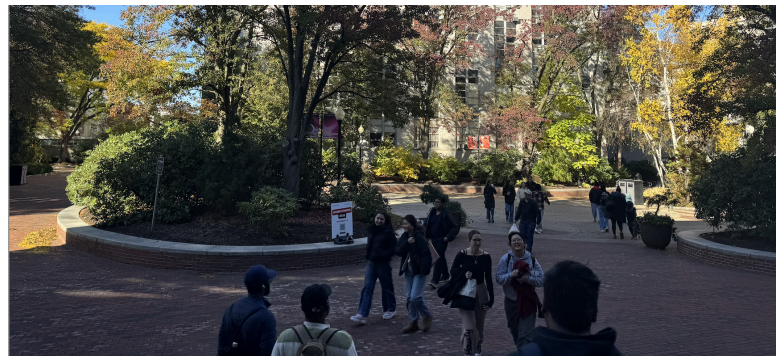
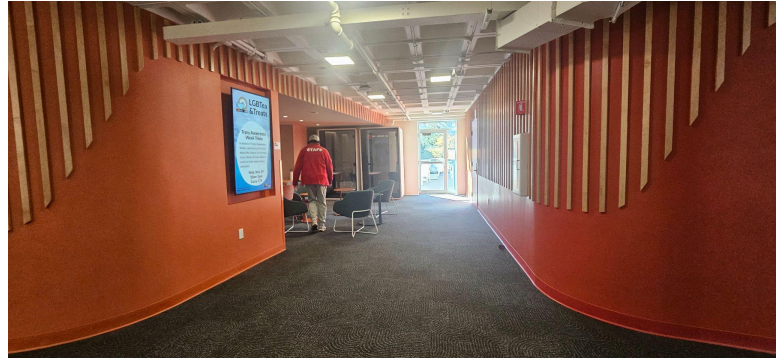
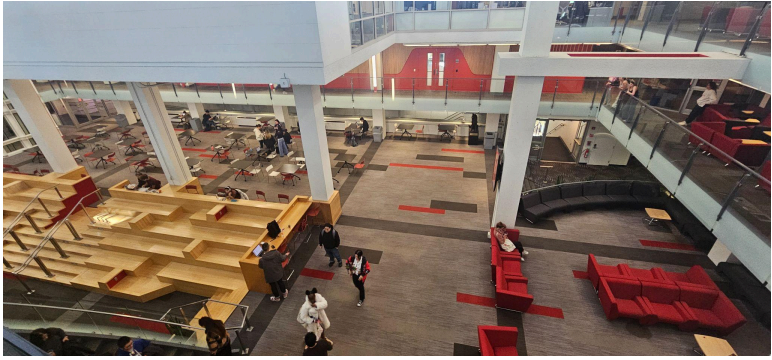
Location 2: Upper Floor

- Actions: People on phones, doing work, on laptops messaging, on facetime, eating, working on presentations, classrooms full of students learning something, group of students holding flowers (maybe celebrating something), walking and listening to music with coffees in hand, rushing to get to a certain place
- Conversations/Relationships: Most conversations are between roommates and suitemates
- Moods: Happy/cheerful vibe, studious (quiet and focused on work), busy, chill/casual

Location 3: Outside Curry (Snell Library Quad)

- Actions: Exclusively walking (not many people sitting around), either by themselves or alone, around 60-70% with headphones in (but not all listening to music, some on calls)
- Conversations/Relationships: No more than 3 people walking together, very engaged in their conversations
- Moods: Distracted, energetic (walking with determination to get somewhere), calm/peaceful, tired, productive

Photos



Mapping Brainstorm

Topic Ideas

- Want to track movement: focusing on areas where walking is more prevalent
- How people walking in groups, pairs, individual affects identity
- Songs people listen to (by genre) and how they're feeling on two different/contrasting days- do certain songs influence emotion or does emotion influence songs picked?
- People with beverages in hand at different times of day - what types of beverages, temperature, colors, etc.
- Conversations had in a certain area

Mapping details

- Colors representing emotion
- Simple sketches representing tasks
- Different fonts for different days of the week
- Different direction of lines for different days
- Mood (colors)
- Song/Genre (direction)

Final Topic: Mapping Music Genres and Feelings Across Contrasting Days

Potential Questions

- Do certain music genres correlate with certain emotional states?
- Is the emotional mood more affected by the music chosen or the environment and time of day?
- How do emotional expressions differ when students listen to music alone (with headphones) versus interacting with friends?

Data Collection Process

- Ask people walking through the area two things:
 - What song they are currently listening to
 - How does it makes them feel
- Focus on two days/timeframes: Friday afternoon/evening (Halloween) and Sunday morning
- Classify songs by set genre groups and emotion groups
- Map locations where students gather and listen to specific genres and feelings

Goals

- To create an unconventional map that reveals the emotional and musical setting of the quad

- Depict how music and mood are represented in everyday life, especially with students
- To see how different environments and timing influence what we listen to and our emotions

Data Collection - Songs & Emotions

Friday October 31, 2025

4:00 PM - 4:15 PM

Cloudy, 40*

Name of Song + Artist	Genre	Emotion/Feeling
I Put A Spell On You - Annie Lennox	Rock	Powerful
CLOVER - Cannelle	Indie / Alternative	Happy
Follow God - Kanye West	Hip-Hop / R&B	Energetic
Stateside - PinkPantheress	Hip-Hop / R&B	Energetic
Bloody Mary - Lady Gaga	Pop / Alt Pop	Powerful
Message in a Bottle - Oscar blue	Indie / Alternative	Sad
Santa - Rvssian	Global / International	Energetic
White cat - Yves	K-Pop / Dance Pop	Happy
Mona Lisa - Dominic Fike	Indie / Alternative	Happy
Mr Rager - Kid Cudi	Hip-Hop / R&B	Energetic
Mad About You - Hooverphonic	Indie / Alternative	Energetic
R u ok? - ifeye	K-Pop / Dance Pop	Energetic
Circadian Rhythm - Drake	Hip-Hop / R&B	Happy
Glory Pox - Portishead	Rock	Powerful
Glitter - lexycat	Indie / Alternative	Energetic

Sunday November 2, 2025

1:00 PM - 1:15 PM

Sunny, 59*

Name of Song + Artist	Genre	Emotion/Feeling
Sex is Powerful - MARINA	Pop / Alt Pop	Powerful
Into It - Chase Atlantic	Pop / Alt Pop	Tired
Titi Me Pregunto - Bad Bunny	Global / International	Happy
Feel Like A Stranger - Grateful Dead	Indie / Alternative	Energetic
Past Lives - sapientdream	Indie / Alternative	Happy
Rodrick Rules - Malcolm Todd	Indie / Alternative	Happy
Vaaroon - Anand Bhaskar	Global / International	Romantic
In my head - Ariana Grande	Pop / Alt Pop	Powerful
Pt. 2 - Kanye West	Hip-Hop / R&B	Energetic
Young Dumb and Broke - Khalid	Pop / Alt Pop	Happy
Savior Complex - Phoebe Bridgers	Indie / Alternative	Sad
Ditto - NewJeans	K-Pop / Dance Pop	Happy
Drama - Aespa	K-Pop / Dance Pop	Energetic
Blue - PinkPantheress	Indie / Alternative	Energetic
Location - Playboi Carti	Hip-Hop / R&B	Happy

Final Maps

FRIDAY, OCT 31ST
16:00 - 16:15
CLOUDY, 40°F

- Powerful
- Tired
- Happy
- Romantic
- Energetic
- Sad

SUNDAY, NOV 2ND

13:00 - 13:15

SUNNY, 59°F

- Powerful
- Tired
- Happy
- Romantic
- Energetic
- Sad



Reflection

As you record information to create your map, consider the visual design (layout, typography, map key if any required etc.) of your map and the overall experience of looking at, interpreting and using the map. After completing the mapping exercise, reflect on and respond to the below questions (1 paragraph each) as a team.

What did you decide to map and why?

We decided to map the Snell Library Quad located just outside the Curry Student Center as we realised that it gets the most foot traffic, whether people are commuting between home and campus using the T or visiting the library between classes. We expected this area to be where people would be mostly walking by at busy times of the day. This space offers a natural setting to observe different behaviour. We also figured that when people are walking, they usually listen to music at that time and aren't focused on work or class at that moment as compared to if they were sitting down and working. This could suggest that emotions are more easily identifiable and range across different categories. We specifically focused on the songs people were listening to and their moods/emotions because we wanted to explore the relationship between music and emotion in a public setting.

Whose story are you telling with your map and whose story are you not telling?

The story we are telling are the students of Northeastern and their daily routine based on their mood as expressed through their music choices on contrasting days. We picked two different days (Friday and Sunday) that we thought would have the biggest contrast. Friday (Halloween) is a day to celebrate finishing the week and getting ready for the exciting weekend, while Sunday is focused on resetting for the upcoming week and is considered a day of rest and relaxation. This essentially captures how students' emotional states and music preferences shift between a festive evening and a quiet weekend morning. It also depicts the relationship between specific genres and emotional feelings. The Snell Quad is located on Northeastern University Campus grounds, and so the range of people does not reach the general population, like those going to work, people going to school, etc. It is limited to primarily Northeastern students. This map also excludes people who aren't listening to music or weren't comfortable with sharing their song choices with us.

What problems and opportunities does looking at the NU campus/neighborhood/Boston through your map reveal to us?

Looking at the Northeastern University campus and neighborhood through our map can reveal certain problems relating to students every-day lives highlighting the connection between

mood, music, and time. Every student has their own fixed schedule and routine, and the genre of music they are listening to at different times of the day can demonstrate their emotional and mental state; such as, on a Monday morning the student can feel tired so maybe they will listen to rap music to hype them up and give them more energy for the day. Or if they are feeling a little down and so they listen to a somber tune. Mapping out the Snell Library Quad through music genre and mood can help unveil a pattern in Northeastern campus life and reflect a certain consensus that all students share in their hardships and community. Our map can also indicate how the environment can affect mood by showing how different areas of the Snell Library Quad could inflict different types of music based on a person's surroundings.

Proposal

I. Abstract

Our proposed idea explores how an intervention can reveal individuals' emotions in mobile environments. Using the Snell Library Quad as our intervention space, we developed an instruction set where people can express their emotions nonverbally through color and pathway choices. The proposal outlines our site research, the overall concept, inspirations from past examples and suggested artists, and the intended interaction.

II. Extended Site Research (Anya)

After finishing our mapping submission, we went back to Snell Library Quad to conduct further research on the space. We went back at different times to understand how the space functions at various times of the day. One thing we noticed across almost all times is that people do not tend to linger in the area, but instead just pass through. Almost everyone is in transit, whether heading to class or to grab food in Curry. People also tend to move in a directional flow, following the same paths that are naturally created. The only place to pause, socialize, or look around is towards the sides where people use the ledges to sit, often in between classes. However, the quad behaves more like a circulatory system than a gathering space.

We also noted how the temperature affected moods and behaviours while walking through the space. For example, when it is colder out, people walk faster and appear less aware of those around them (more driven towards getting to their destination). There also seemed to be less traffic when it's colder, possibly due to a variety of factors like people intentionally skipping their activities for the day or utilizing the underground tunnels. When it is warmer, more people are involved in conversations with friends as they walk.

Based on this research, we were able to conclude that this space imposes clear constraints on what kinds of interventions will be effective. A traditional interaction similar to the The Ball example would not be as successful in this space, because people rarely stop walking and any intervention that requires reading, pausing, or thoughtful participation would be ignored. An experience that could be engaged on while moving seemed more feasible because it integrates with the flow of walking rather than disrupting it. The design of the intervention itself, incorporating various colors and symbols act as visual signifiers that can be understood well while walking.

III. Intervention Proposal: Chalk Pathways (Maya)

For this intervention, we chose to locate it on the Snell Library Quad because there's enough foot traffic there to create an effect. Building on our Mapping an Experience task, we decided to use this intervention to visualize the different emotions people are feeling as they walk through, and to investigate what emotions are most commonly felt during different times of the week.

To visualize this idea, we are planning to create six running paths drawn and color on the library quad with different colored chalks. Each color represents a different emotion: red for feeling powerful, grey for fatigue, yellow for happy, orange for energetic, pink for romantic, and blue for sad. When people see a colored line or track on the ground, the intuitive reaction is that it's meant for people to walk on. Our intervention uses this visual clue to invite people walking through the area to walk over these colorful paths.

However, a question came up: how will people know which emotion corresponds to each color? After discussing it as a group, we didn't want to use plain text labels like "powerful," "tired," or "happy" on the paths. First, the quad is a busy area, and it's not realistic to expect people to stop on their way to class and read words on the floor. Second, it just isn't as fun! Instead, we'll use white chalk to draw emojis and simple cartoon drawings that reflect each emotion at the beginning and end of each path. This way, people walking by don't have to spend a lot of effort understanding how to interact, which increases the likelihood they'll actually engage with the intervention.

Throughout the process, we plan to set up a time-lapse camera to capture all the people passing by and interacting with the different colored paths. After a set period of time (like an hour), we can compare the before and after state of the paths, observing the color and opacity of each track. The fainter a path looks, the more popular that emotion was among people who interacted with it. This works because the more people walk over an area of chalk, the more chalk gets carried away on their shoes, making the colors fainter. This lets us observe and capture the overall mood and emotion of people traveling through the library quad during a specific time period.

IV. Class Example Inspiration (Abby)

A large part of our idea was inspired by the many examples we have seen in class. One of examples was the Mood Matrix and their way of collecting data. What stood out to us in its design was the utilization of bright and alluring colors, and the simple drawing of faces that represent the range of emotions people might feel during that moment on the Brooklyn Bridge.

The use of color stood out as an important component to representing how people feel, and taking that idea and making it into an interactive experience was a core component into coming up with an idea of how to create something interactive in the Snell Library Quad that will help connect the community. The idea of making the colors into different paths passersby can take comes from another example that was shown in class which was the Dove Campaign For Real Beauty. What stood out was how something as simple as choosing which door to go through based on what it was labeled (beautiful or average), told a lot about how women saw themselves and how there is a general consensus around the world that women have where they think they are average which says a lot about what the definition of beauty means to society. The fact that this campaign did not interrupt anyone's daily routine in a significant way is something that we also want to incorporate within our project. This is due to the fact that many people who pass by the Library Quad are students from Northeastern and many are on their way to class, so their time is precious. This is why we referred to the Dove campaign and came up with the idea of having pathways so that people can simultaneously interact with the project and go on their way.

V. Related Works by Artists & Designers (Viraj)

Our project's focus on nonverbal emotional expression and subtle interaction through movement connects strongly to the work of Hélio Oiticica and Olafur Eliasson, two artists who use color, environment, and bodily participation to guide audience behavior without direct instruction.

Hélio Oiticica is known for creating immersive environments that transform viewers into active participants. His "Parangolés" and other large-scale installations rely on color, texture, and spatial composition as nonverbal cues that encourage people to walk, explore, or gesture intuitively. Oiticica treats color not just as a visual component but as a sensory and emotional experience that shifts mood and perception. This relates directly to our intervention on the Snell Library Quad, where each chalk pathway uses color as an immediate emotional signifier. Like Oiticica's work, our design avoids written instruction; the presence of colored paths and expressive emojis acts as a visual prompt that people can understand instantly while continuing their movement through the space. His focus on bodily navigation through color-rich environments supports our goal of integrating interaction seamlessly into a mobile, high-traffic context.

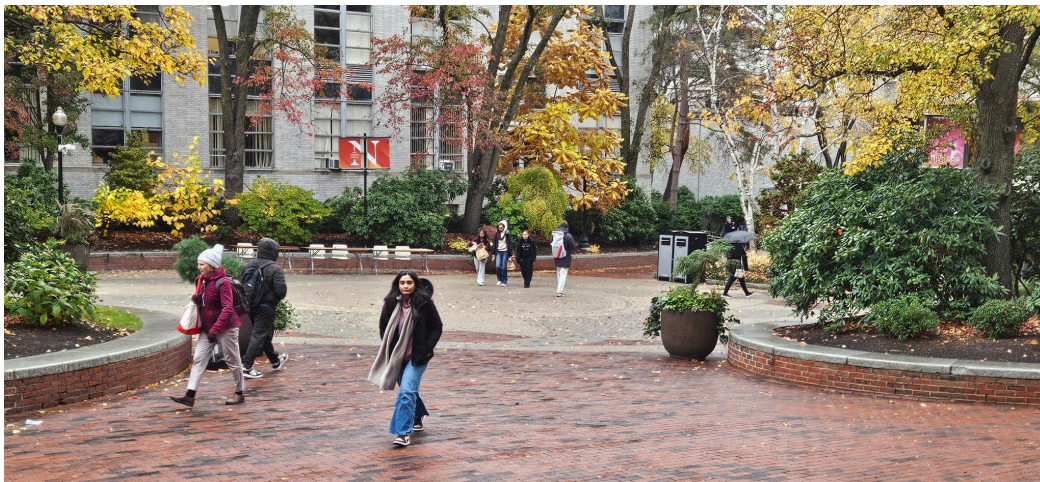
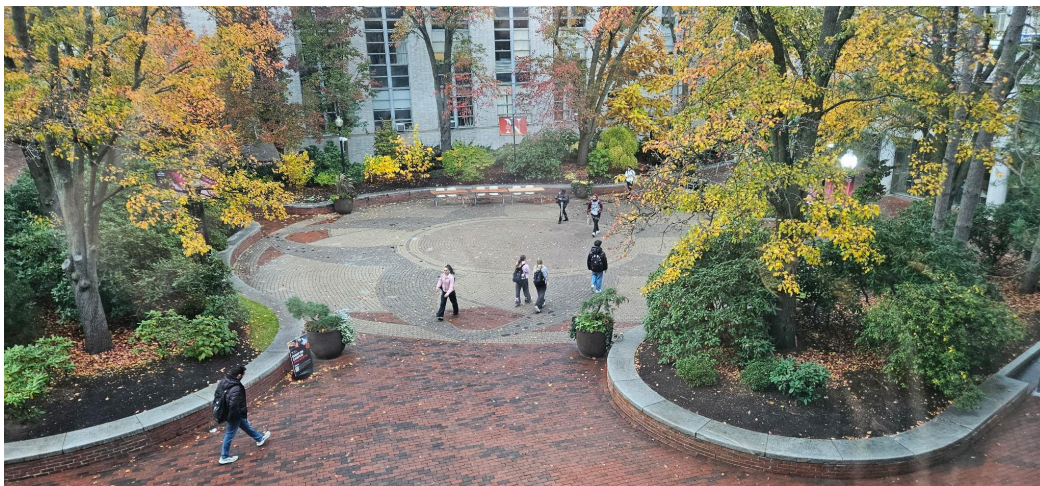
Olafur Eliasson similarly works with nonverbal communication through light, color, atmosphere, and environmental perception. In projects such as "The Weather Project," Eliasson creates situations where simple visual stimuli evoke individual emotional responses while

simultaneously revealing collective patterns of behavior. His installations use subtle cues—rather than explicit directions—to heighten people’s awareness of themselves, others, and the space they move through. Our chalk pathways function in a similar way: instead of verbally asking passersby to express their feelings, the colors and emoji-based symbols act as gentle invitations for emotional expression through walking. Eliasson’s interest in how environmental changes reflect collective behavior parallels our plan to analyze fading chalk over time, using it as a visual record of shared emotional states among people crossing the quad.

Together, Oiticica and Eliasson demonstrate how artists can use color, space, and environmental cues to facilitate interaction and emotional awareness without relying on written language. Their approaches reinforce the core principles of our intervention: nonverbal communication, intuitive participation within everyday movement, and the transformation of a public walkway into an expressive, collective interface.

VI. Media

[Snell Quad Video](#)



INTERVENTION SKETCH:

Fluid
movements

Colors for diff
emotions
↙

No words,
Symbols
↘

